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Usability Test

Evaluating the Usability & Information Architecture of an Academic Portal

Assessing the uoZone platform to improve findability, navigation clarity, and user confidence for students managing complex academic workflows.



TEAM STRUCTURE

Group work (5 team members)
Role: Team Lead

TOOL

Loop11

TIME FRAME

Jan - Feb 2026

RESPONSIBILITY

UX Researcher (Led usability testing & moderation)

Overview

uoZone is a critical academic platform, but students struggle to find key information due to unclear navigation and poor information structure, leading to confusion, inefficiency, and reliance on external search. These issues increase task completion time, reduce user confidence, and force users to rely on external tools.

Research Objectives

To identify and resolve these usability issues, our research evaluated user interactions across 6 key tasks, measuring:



Effectiveness

Task completion rates and error recovery.



Efficiency

Time on task, click paths, and navigation detours.



Satisfaction

Perceived usability and emotional response, measured via the System Usability Scale (SUS)

Overview

Methodology

Research & Data Analysis

Key Findings & Insights

Recommendation

Reflection

Methodology

Set up	Participants	Moderation Approach	Task Overview	Metrics
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Test Type Remote Moderated Usability Test	Tool 	Tested Device Desktop
Number of Participants 5	Number of Tasks 6	Test Duration Approx. 30-45 minutes

Set up

Participants

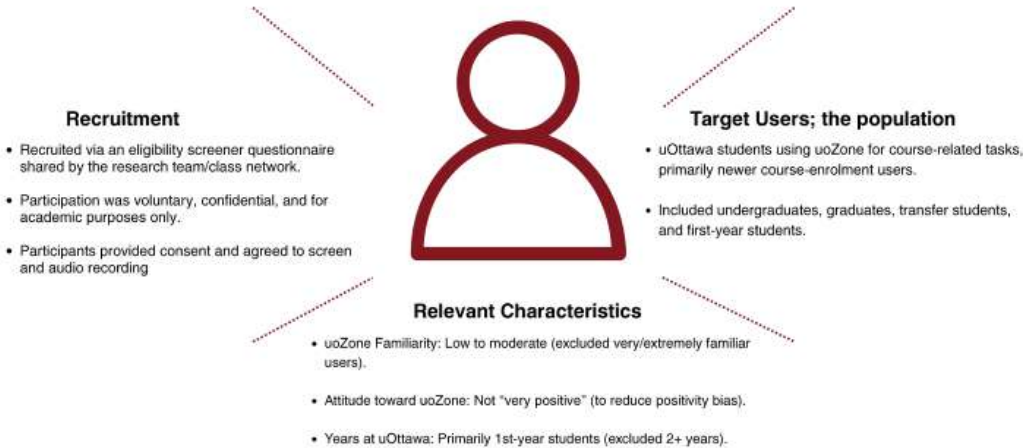
Moderation Approach

Task Overview

Metrics

We recruited 5 uOttawa students (Undergrad, Grad, and PhD) using a targeted screener to ensure high-quality, unbiased data.

About the Participants



Set up

Participants

Moderation Approach

Task Overview

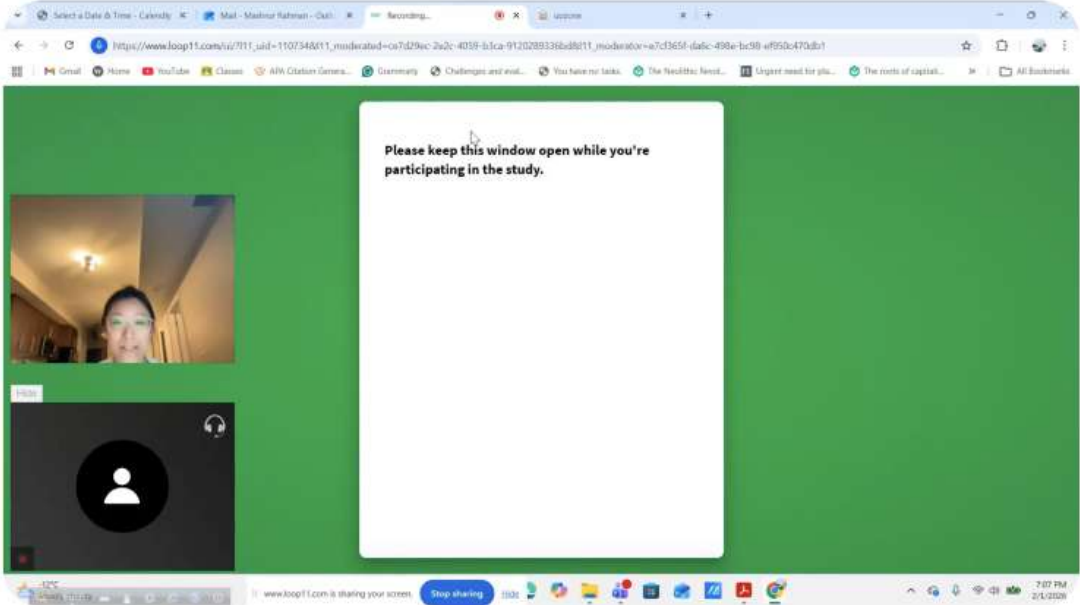
Metrics

1. Think-Aloud Protocol

Participants were asked to verbalize their thought process, expectations, and moments of confusion in real-time.

2. Neutral Facilitation

To capture authentic user behavior, we avoided guiding the participants, letting them fail or find workarounds naturally to expose true system flaws.



Set up

Participants

Moderation Approach

Task Overview

Metrics

We designed 6 scenario-based tasks focusing on critical academic and administrative goals, chosen for their high usage frequency

Task Overview

Task 1 View degree progress & remaining courses	Task 2 Find your unofficial transcript	Task 3 Change your preferred name
Task 4 Check your exam schedule	Task 5 Register for volunteer work	Task 6 Request your co-curricular record

Set up

Participants

Moderation Approach

Task Overview

Metrics



- **Time on task**
Time to complete the task or reach a clear stopping point
- **Errors and breakdown points**
Misclicks, wrong paths, backtracking, and where the flow “broke”
- **Post-task rating scale using the same scale after every task**
- **Task outcome**
Success, Success with hint, Fail (we explicitly noted when a hint was given)
- **Issue severity**
Minor, Major, Critical (especially when errors caused abandonment or failure)
- **Observations & think-aloud quotes**
What participants did and said while completing the task

Research & Data Analysis

We applied multiple usability testing methods and data analyses to uncover where and why uOttawa students experience friction, confusion, or drop off when navigating the uoZone platform.

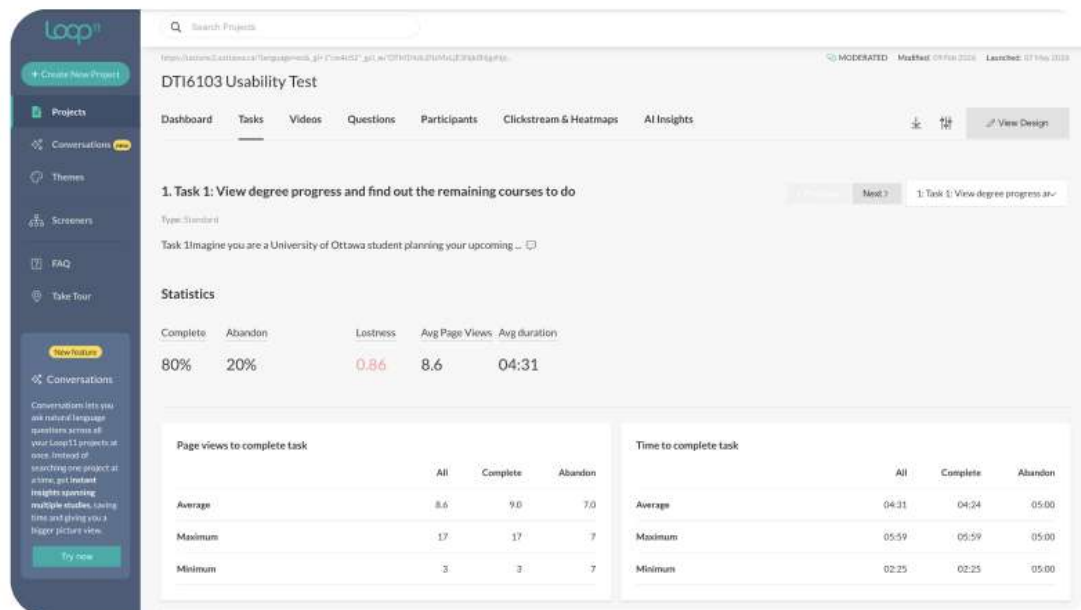
Quantitative Metrics

Click Path Analysis

Qualitative & SUS Analysis

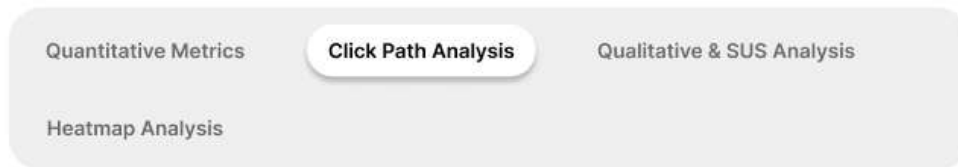
Heatmap Analysis

We analyzed performance data from Loop11, including task success/abandonment rates, time-on-task, and page views, to objectively measure system efficiency and effectiveness.

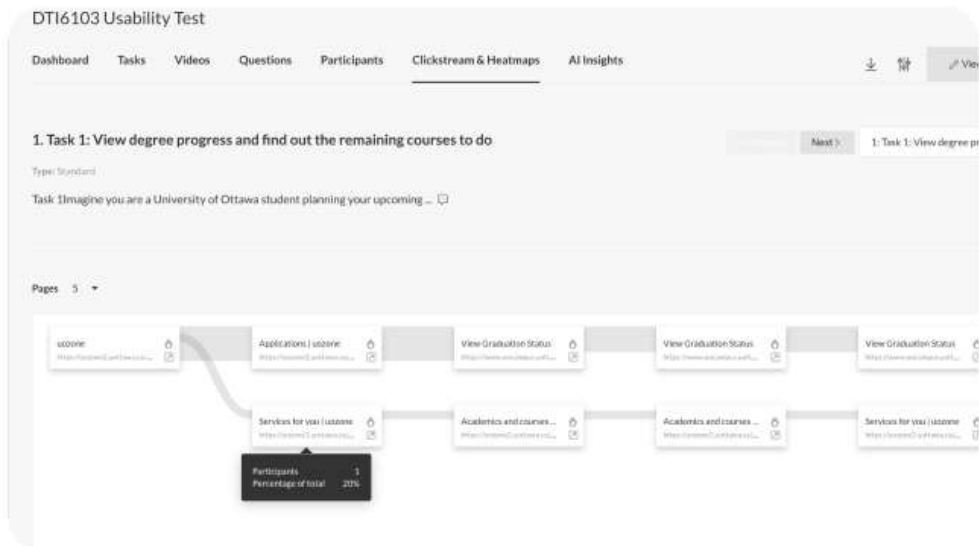


Research & Data Analysis

We applied multiple usability testing methods and data analyses to uncover where and why uOttawa students experience friction, confusion, or drop off when navigating the uoZone platform.



By tracking users' actual navigation flows against expected paths, we identified severe mental model mismatches and navigation detours.



Research & Data Analysis

We applied multiple usability testing methods and data analyses to uncover where and why uOttawa students experience friction, confusion, or drop off when navigating the uoZone platform.



Through the Think-Aloud protocol and post-task System Usability Scale (SUS) questionnaires, we synthesized behavioral observations, emotional responses, and user quotes.

A	B	C	D	E	F
	Participant 1	Participant 2	Participant 3	Participant 4	Participant 5
applied the criteria, accuracy)					
Did they check the 'Applications' first? - to learn	Application-Looking one by one for "Unofficial Transcript"	Application-Looking one by one for "Unofficial Transcript"	Application-Looking one by one for "Unofficial Transcript"	Student center->Under Academics-> Other Academic Information Dropdown-> Transcript_View Unofficial->"View report" button	Application-Looking one by one for "Unofficial Transcript"
excludes the "Unofficial Transcript" application status the dropdown menus (Institution, Report)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
excludes the "View report" button.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
if	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
if	No	No	Yes	No	No
if:					
e you were unsure whether you were viewing the	No	No	Yes, She doesn't know what is UT	No	No
effort, time, and resources users spent to					
	2m12s	2m18s	5m09s	1m19	1m19
	4	5		7	3
	3	3	8	1	3
for rate	0				
if	N/A				
if than what we expected? if so, where? Why?	No			Student center->Under Academics-> Other Academic Information Dropdown-> Transcript_View Unofficial->"View report" button. He used to use "Student center"	
	Difficult.	Easy (difficult to find manually) He click 3 times "View Report". Because he didn't see the loading button on the top right corner. After 3 clicks, he could find unofficial transcript status.	Difficult.	Easy He click many times "View Report", because he didn't see the loading button on the top right corner, after some time, report pop up. He realized it was not stuck, just loading process.	Easy
	Easy if use "search bar/need to check many applications)		She doesn't know what is "UI"		
steps than expected	Agree *	Agree *	Agree *	Agree *	Agree *
	More a lot than he thought	Take long time to locate "unofficial			

Research & Data Analysis

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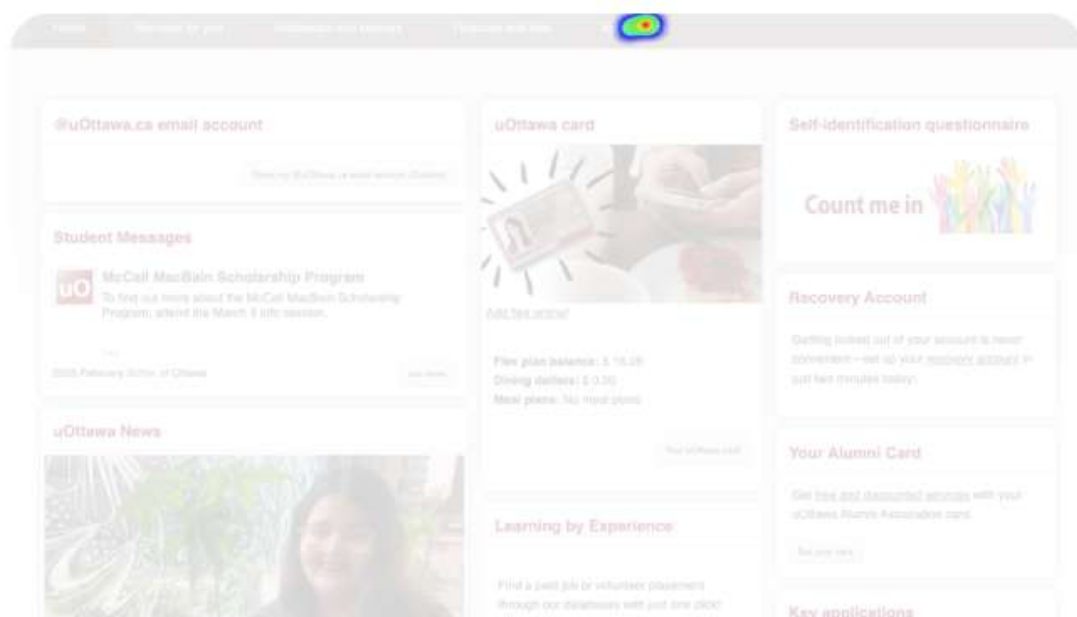
Quantitative Metrics

Click Path Analysis

Qualitative & SUS Analysis

Heatmap Analysis

We utilized first-click heatmaps to visualize user attention and initial decision-making.



Key Findings & Insights

Theme 1

Theme 2

Theme 3

Severe Findability Issues & External Search Reliance

Insight

Pain point

Evidence

Critical features are deeply hidden, causing massive task abandonment and forcing users to rely on external search engines (e.g., Google)

Key Findings & Insights

Theme 1

Theme 2

Theme 3

Severe Findability Issues & External Search Reliance

Insight

Pain point

Evidence

The "Applications" page is severely overloaded with similar icons. Finding non-frequent tools like "Volunteer Registration" or "Co-Curricular Record (CCR)" creates extreme cognitive overload

Key Findings & Insights

Theme 1

Theme 2

Theme 3

Severe Findability Issues & External Search Reliance

Insight

Pain point

Evidence

- **80% Abandonment Rate:** 4 out of 5 users completely abandoned the volunteer registration task, rating it "Extremely difficult".
- **High Interaction Cost:** Users navigated up to 17 pages looking for their CCR, with only a 20% success rate. 40% of users switched to Google out of frustration.
- **User Quotes:** "I need to look through a thousand buttons... I feel clueless." / "I probably just go Google."

Recommendation

Navigation & Information Architecture (IA)

Findability & Discoverability

Labeling & Terminology

Visual Hierarchy & Interface Efficiency

Feedback & System Status

1. Navigation & Information Architecture (IA)

Issue 1.1 Students experience difficulty locating degree progress and academic requirements

Severity: Critical

Proposed direction



Recommendations

- Add a visual degree progress indicator on the uOZone homepage.
- Make the indicator clickable → a link to a detailed degree progress page
- Whenever a detailed degree progress is displayed, show overall + category-level progress
 - (1) visually,
 - (2) as a percentage,
 - (3) as a number of credits (completed/needed).

Reflection

Data Discrepancy Analysis

When using Loop11 for Usability Testing, system issues arose, affecting participants' ability to complete the tests. This meant the test results couldn't be used directly; video recordings were required. Therefore, instead of relying on automatically generated reports, I manually reviewed the video recordings, recalculated metrics, and ensured data integrity.

Actions Over Opinions

This project reinforced a core UX principle: what users do matters far more than what they say. This was achieved by analyzing actual click path deviations and task abandonment rates, rather than simply soliciting opinions.